

Checklist

Strategy for Platforms

1. Strategic Foundation

- ☐ Define **why** a platform strategy is needed.
- ☐ Connect the platform strategy to the organization's **business strategy**.
- ☐ Account for the organization's unique assets, constraints, and competitive environment.
- ☐ Avoid copying another organization's platform strategy without adapting it.
- ☐ Treat business strategy and technology strategy as a **two-way relationship**.
- ☐ Focus on increasing the organization's **rate of change**, not merely reaching a fixed target state.

2. Context, Objectives, Mechanisms & Design Decisions

- ☐ **Context:** Explain why the organization is pursuing a platform strategy.
- ☐ **Objectives:** Identify and prioritize the most important business outcomes.
- ☐ **Mechanisms:** Explain how platform capabilities will produce those outcomes.
- ☐ **Design decisions:** Document the important implementation trade-offs.
- ☐ Make the connection between context → objectives → mechanisms → design decisions explicit.
- ☐ Avoid replacing mechanisms with buzzwords such as “DevOps” or “microservices.”
- ☐ Make technical decisions understandable to business and technology stakeholders.

The source recommends these four connected layers specifically to avoid the “IT Hourglass” problem in strategy documents.

3. Transformation & Ways of Working

- ☐ Identify which existing ways of working must change.
- ☐ Distinguish **transformation** from simply upgrading or optimizing technology.
- ☐ Determine which old constraints the platform can remove.
- ☐ Translate new technical capabilities into improved user experiences or business value.
- ☐ Look for opportunities to achieve both **speed and quality** through automation.
- ☐ Look for opportunities to achieve both **speed and compliance**.
- ☐ Challenge the assumption that innovation and harmonization must be opposites.

Upgrading technology without changing how the organization works is described as optimization rather than transformation.

4. Platform Design

- ☐ Define clear, reusable components and their relationships.
- ☐ Separate **commodity capabilities** from true differentiators.
- ☐ Use common interfaces and standards where they enable reuse.
- ☐ Hide unnecessary underlying complexity from platform users.
- ☐ Keep onboarding and consumption friction low.
- ☐ Allow users enough freedom to build solutions you did not anticipate.
- ☐ Avoid designing an all-encompassing “IT pyramid” that attempts to predict every use case.
- ☐ Continuously review platform boundaries as technologies and user needs evolve.
- ☐ Treat the way users interact with the platform as seriously as the functionality inside it.

The text emphasizes that platforms should not anticipate every use case; instead, standardization underneath should enable diversity and innovation above.

5. Governance & Autonomy

- ☐ Centralize reusable expertise where it creates economies of scale.
- ☐ Decentralize platform usage and innovation to individual teams.
- ☐ Separate **operational control** from **user control**.
- ☐ Use automation and shared-responsibility models as governance mechanisms.
- ☐ Provide guardrails without creating excessive approval or ticket-based friction.
- ☐ Be willing to relinquish some central control so users can innovate.

Platforms can combine central governance with decentralized usage and innovation.

6. Map the Platform Landscape

- ☐ Identify the user or customer needs that anchor the platform.
- ☐ Map the components required to meet those needs.
- ☐ Determine which components are **genesis, custom-built, product, or commodity**.
- ☐ Identify components likely to be commoditized over time.
- ☐ Identify opportunities for componentization and reuse.
- ☐ Use a Wardley Map or similar model to understand platform evolution.
- ☐ Monitor platform usage for signals that certain capabilities should become shared platform services.

Wardley Maps are used in the text to examine component evolution and the effects of commoditization and componentization.

7. Roadmap & Execution

- ☐ Define the **point**: where the organization wants to go.
- ☐ Define the **path**: how it intends to get there.
- ☐ Understand the **terrain**: risks, uncertainty, and environmental changes.
- ☐ Ensure the roadmap begins from the organization's actual current state.
- ☐ Avoid assuming only a "happy path."
- ☐ Identify important future decision points.
- ☐ Identify alternative paths that may be taken.
- ☐ Specify what data will be needed to make future decisions.
- ☐ Allow tactics to change while preserving the overall strategic direction.

A strategic roadmap should anticipate decision points, possible paths, and the information needed to choose between them rather than pretending execution will be linear.

8. Strategy Communication

- ☐ Emphasize the most important ideas rather than attempting to document everything.
- ☐ Explicitly state what is **not included** in the strategy.
- ☐ Use simple conceptual models where they reduce complexity.
- ☐ Write for a broad human audience, not only technical specialists.
- ☐ Ensure objectives, mechanisms, and technical choices form a coherent story.

- ☐ Keep the document concise enough that decision-makers can understand its central argument.

9. ACED Quality Check

Before approving the strategy, confirm that you have **ACED** it:

- ☐ **Alignment** — Does the platform strategy support the IT and business strategies?
- ☐ **Clarity** — Can a broad audience easily understand the strategy?
- ☐ **Evolution** — Can the strategy evolve as opportunities, priorities, and constraints change?
- ☐ **Decisions** — Does the strategy make actual choices and trade-offs rather than merely listing wishes?

The source presents **Alignment, Clarity, Evolution, and Decisions (ACED)** as a simple final checklist for evaluating a strategy document or slide deck.

Final Go/No-Go Check

- ☐ We can clearly explain **why** the platform is needed.
- ☐ We know the measurable business outcomes it should enable.
- ☐ We can explain **how** the proposed mechanisms lead to those outcomes.
- ☐ Major design trade-offs have been made explicitly.
- ☐ The platform changes ways of working rather than merely introducing new technology.
- ☐ Standardization enables rather than suppresses innovation.
- ☐ Users have sufficient autonomy within appropriate guardrails.
- ☐ The roadmap accounts for uncertainty and alternative paths.
- ☐ Platform evolution will be driven by usage data and feedback.
- ☐ The strategy passes the **ACED** test.

